Degrowth

Hello everyone, and welcome! This is episode nine of the Cottongue Podcast!

[00:00:13] If this is your first time listening to this podcast, you should know I make it to help people learning French. Every week, there's a new podcast on a different subject, and with this podcast you can practise understanding something in French. If it's a little difficult, you can use the transcript of this podcast. To find the transcript, you can go to my website, cottongue.com, and register. By registering, you'll get free access to this podcast's transcript. I think the first time you should try listening without the transcript to see what you're able to understand, and afterwards you can use it for the passages, the moments you didn't understand well.

[00:01:34] Today's subject is very interesting because it concerns many different fields. It concerns economics, but also sociology, philosophy and psychology, and I think you'll learn lots of interesting things and enrich your vocabulary.

[00:02:04] Have you ever heard of the Cold War? The Cold War was a period of history in the twentieth century during which two opposing camps existed: the Western camp with the United States, and the Soviet camp with the Soviet Union. In French, we call it "l'URSS", the Soviet Union. You know this Cold War ended in the late eighties. And since the end of the Cold War, the capitalist model has dominated the world. In almost every country, capitalism has established itself as the economic model to follow. People often say it's the only model that can work for our economies. But for capitalism to work, more and more wealth has to be produced. Every year, countries must produce more than the previous year. That's what we call economic growth: when a country produces more wealth than the year before. However, since the seventies, certain groups and economists have wanted to show that growth has negative effects on people and the environment. These people say growth isn't necessarily a good thing, quite the opposite. They call for degrowth, in other words gradually slowing production in developed countries, meaning the United States, Japan, Australia, Canada and European countries. These economists who recommend degrowth say developed countries must change their way of developing. They must stop pursuing growth at any cost.

[00:04:38] This idea is a little counterintuitive. People think these people, these "degrowth advocates", are crazy, strange, utopian people. We imagine they want a return to the past, to the Middle Ages, and that in reality their ideas can't really be applied. Despite that, their ideas are becoming increasingly influential. More and more people are interested in degrowth. Of course, degrowth concerns economics, but not only economics. It also concerns our everyday lives, our habits, how we consume, the things we buy and how we get around. In all these matters, degrowth advocates recommend completely changing our lifestyles.

[00:05:54] So today, we're going to ask whether degrowth is possible, and how we can apply degrowth at our own level. Can we change our lifestyles to have a better impact on the environment, but also to feel better, to have a life that perhaps has more meaning?

[00:06:25] Are you ready to talk about degrowth? Then here we go!

[00:06:37] I told you in the introduction to this podcast that the capitalist model is based on growth. The economy has to produce. In other words, people have to work to produce goods and services, and consumers, us, buy these products or services. Every year, we have to produce more, sell more and consume more.

[00:07:18] Degrowth advocates think this is a vicious circle, in other words things that have negative consequences for each other. And they say this race for growth is something that makes no sense. Because the world we live in is limited: resources are limited, our time is limited, since we aren't immortal. So with all these limits, there will inevitably come a point when we can no longer produce more. Degrowth advocates therefore think we must seek other alternatives, other solutions.

[00:08:18] This race for growth is impossible in the long term, but it also has negative consequences for the environment. This is something we all know: when we produce and consume, it affects the environment. For example, factories where we produce cars or mobile phones use many resources and then pollute. But also when we travel, when we use a car or take a plane, there's a lot of pollution there too. You've probably heard of global warming, for example: the fact that human activity, production and consumption activity, causes temperature changes.

[00:09:30] Besides pollution, we're gradually exhausting resources. To "exhaust resources" means using all the resources so that soon none will remain. Environmentalists think that in several years, certain resources will have completely disappeared, for example oil, uranium, aluminium, coal, gas and so on. All these resources we use for production, well, in a few years they'll have completely disappeared.

[00:10:16] But growth also has negative consequences for people, not only for the environment, but directly for us. Why? Simply because this growth also brings mass unemployment. Unemployment is when people look for work but can't find any. For example, when there's an economic crisis, many people lose their jobs. And of course, these economic crises are linked to growth.

[00:11:02] If more and more people don't have work, that means they're becoming poorer, and all this can lead us into a very complicated situation, a situation such as war, for example. So that's another consequence of this capitalist model, and something degrowth advocates fight against.

[00:11:41] Now we're going to talk in a little more detail about these degrowth advocates, these people who support the idea of degrowth. First, I'm going to tell you a little more about their philosophy. The idea of degrowth is to escape the logic of "always more". More products, more objects, more clothes: we must produce more, sell more, buy more. Degrowth advocates think that's bad reasoning, and that we must adopt a completely different philosophy, a completely different logic.

[00:12:32] The problem with growth is that we focus exclusively on having, on possessing things, cars, houses and so on. And we no longer focus at all on being, on the person we are, our values, the things we want to do. We focus exclusively on the things we own, and when we do that, we tend to stop asking questions.

[00:13:15] Degrowth advocates think that if we own fewer things, in reality we can live better. Because we have less frustration, we don't spend our time buying new things or looking for things to buy, but focus on things that are more important.

[00:13:42] Of course, this transition must happen gradually. Little by little, we need to reduce global production. If we decide to stop producing overnight, the consequences will be disastrous. But if every year we try to produce a little less and consume a little less, degrowth becomes possible. Of course, developed countries must set an example because in developed countries, people already have enough wealth to live. In developing countries, however, obviously we can't recommend degrowth. These countries still need to increase wealth to meet basic needs, for example food, education and people's safety.

[00:14:56] To do this, all countries must agree to pollute less. Pollution is a problem that concerns us all. It doesn't concern only the United States, China or European Union countries. It concerns everyone. So if we want to reduce pollution, all countries must agree. You know there's an organisation called COP, and this organisation tries to encourage countries to agree to reduce pollution, to reduce CO2 emissions. Unfortunately, recently the American President decided to withdraw from these agreements: the United States won't respect the Paris agreements. Personally, I think that's a bit of a shame.

[00:16:16] Another solution for applying degrowth is to reduce working time. If everyone decides to work a little less, we'll be able to create new jobs for people who are unemployed. We must accept reducing our working time so everyone can have work.

[00:16:47] In the context of globalisation, this may seem difficult to implement because countries compete with one another. That's why agreements need to be adopted at an international level.

[00:17:13] But at our individual level, as consumers, as inhabitants, we too can do many things to participate in this movement.

[00:17:34] Degrowth, of course, concerns our everyday lives first. Degrowth advocates try to consume less. They try to see which products are truly necessary and which they don't need. They know advertising creates needs. Companies want to make us believe we need this new phone or this new car. But when we think about it a little more, we realise that ultimately perhaps we don't need all these things. They aren't vital for us. We tend to believe owning more things will make us happier. But in fact, many studies have shown that isn't the case. When you buy your first car, you're very happy because it gives you freedom and lets you get around more easily. But if you buy a second, a third or a fourth car, it won't increase your happiness at all. It won't give you anything more. So the first thing to do is consume less.

[00:19:18] We also need to promote recycling. "Recycling" is when we find a way to reuse products we've thrown away. For example, when we throw something in the bin, that thing can be recycled to create a new product. That's what we call recycling.

[00:19:51] Degrowth advocates also try to favour sharing over buying. For example, they think we can lend our car to our neighbour rather than buying a new car. Or if you need a tool to do some DIY, you can borrow it from a friend instead of buying another one.

[00:20:24] Degrowth advocates also try to pay attention to their water and electricity consumption. They want to avoid waste. “Waste” is when we use up something unnecessarily. For example, if you buy food, don’t eat it and throw it away, that’s waste. Of course, waste is very bad for the environment.

[00:20:58] Another solution concerning everyday life is buying locally, in other words buying products made locally. When we do that, it causes less pollution because there’s no need to transport these products from one country to another, and of course that’s better for the environment.

[00:21:25] You know another important source of pollution is transport. For degrowth advocates, it’s better to use public transport: buses, the metro and so on. And they prefer taking their bicycle to their car because, of course, cycling doesn’t pollute.

[00:21:56] Another thing degrowth advocates try to change is work. In our capitalist societies, work occupies a central place. But it hasn’t always been like that. In other societies or at other times, such as the Middle Ages, work wasn’t necessarily central. But now, in our capitalist societies, work defines our identity. It defines our social status and living conditions through the salary we earn. To move up the social hierarchy, we have to work hard. Of course, that means making many sacrifices. We sacrifice our time and energy. This can cause a lot of pressure for people, a lot of stress. A condition appeared a few years ago called burnout. This condition is linked to pressure, to stress in companies. Because employees are increasingly stressed, sometimes they have no energy left at all.

[00:23:22] It’s very difficult for many people to find a balance between their private and professional lives. Sometimes we sacrifice our private life, family or leisure to give everything, devote everything to our professional life. By contrast, degrowth advocates decide to work less or find a position that lets them work from home. When we work less, we have more time to do other things. More time to spend with family, to do things that interest us or to learn new skills, for example to learn to play the piano. By contrast, when we work all the time, we have no energy left to think when we leave work. The only pleasure left is spending the money we’ve earned and buying products. Buying products doesn’t require much intellectual reflection. It’s easy, and for a short moment it gives us pleasure. But afterwards, this pleasure disappears very quickly. This pleasure is very fleeting. It’s like buying a new mobile phone: before buying it, you’re very impatient. Once you’ve bought it, you’re happy for a few days. Then it becomes something completely normal and gives you no pleasure any more. So if you work less, you have more time to think and do things that give you more lasting pleasure.

[00:25:33] There’s also the question of values. Some people decide to leave their work, to resign, because they think their work has no meaning or because their position isn’t in line with their personal values. These people decide to earn less money but do something they find useful, for example useful to others, or things that are in line with their values. Personally, that’s the decision I made. Before, I worked in a large advertising agency in Paris, but I realised what I was doing didn’t interest me at all and was ultimately rather useless. And when I became a French teacher, I found much more satisfaction because I could help other people enrich themselves, develop personally through French. And that’s something that gives me a great deal of pleasure.

[00:26:59] Making these decisions, for example deciding to work less to earn less money, obviously isn’t possible for everyone. It’s more an attitude we find among the middle classes. For people who already have money problems, problems paying their rent, obviously it isn’t a possible option. That’s one criticism sometimes made of degrowth advocates. People say degrowth is reserved for those who already have money and don’t need to earn more.

[00:27:48] I think everyone can draw inspiration from the philosophy of degrowth. We can ask questions about our consumption and our work, and try to change our habits a little.

[00:28:10] In conclusion, for me degrowth is something very interesting because it encourages us to ask questions about our lifestyle, to reflect on the impact of our decisions on people and the environment. Perhaps these ideas are a little utopian, but more and more people are beginning to adopt them. In Australia, for example, but also in the United States, France and other European countries. These people decide to pay more attention to their consumption and try to pollute less. I think we’re increasingly aware of our impact and try to make efforts to limit our negative impact on the environment. In my opinion, it’s always good to ask questions and try to have a more positive influence on our environment and the people around us. But perhaps I’m wrong, perhaps you have a different view. So if you disagree with me, don’t hesitate to send me an email to present your arguments. Reading a viewpoint different from mine is always very interesting to me.

[00:29:58] That’s all for today. We’re coming to the end of this podcast. I hope you had a good time and that you’ll want to listen to this podcast several times.

[00:30:13] Next week, we’re going to talk about a completely different subject, a rather psychological subject, because I’ll tell you about an experiment by an American researcher called Stanley Milgram. So have a good week, and we’ll see each other again soon.